"IN THE BEGINNING..."

GENESIS 41

IN 5 MINUTES

When:

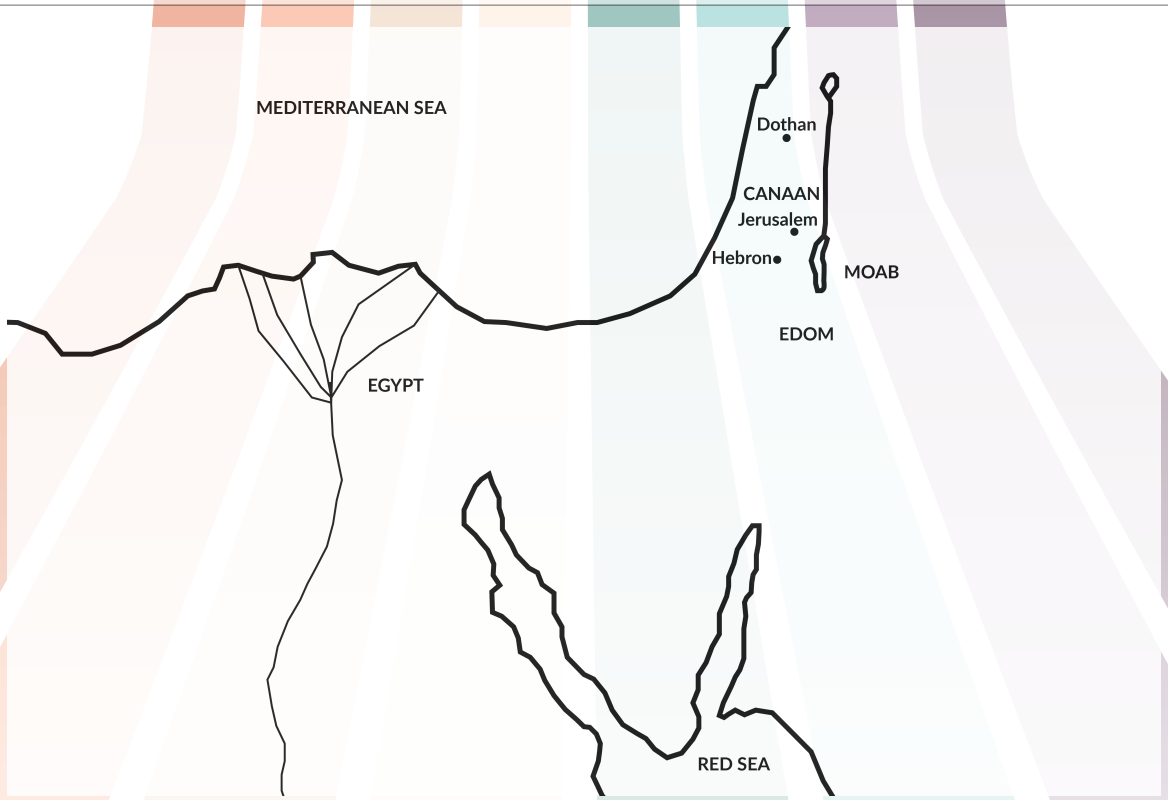
- Joseph was 17 when he went to Egypt (approximately 1728 B.C.).
- Genesis 41 records events that happened when Joseph was 30 years old (1715 B.C.).

Characters:

- Joseph – Jacob's son with Rachel. Joseph's brothers sold him into slavery in Egypt.
- Pharaoh – The king of Egypt
- Chief Cupbearer – Pharaoh's cupbearer who had previously spent time with Joseph in prison.
- Manasseh and Ephraim – The sons of Joseph.

Where:

- The story contained in Genesis 41 took place in the country of Egypt.
- We are not given specifics as to the region or city.



Outline:

- PHARAOH'S DREAMS (41:1-8):
    + Two years after the chief cupbearer and chief baker's dreams were fulfilled, Pharaoh, the king of Egypt, dreamed two dreams.
    + When he awoke, he was troubled and called his magicians and wise men to interpret the dreams, but they couldn't.
- JOSEPH INTERPRETS PHARAOH'S DREAMS (41:9-36):
    + The chief cupbearer approached Pharaoh and told him about the Hebrew boy who had interpreted his dream in prison.
    + Pharaoh summoned Joseph.
    + Pharaoh told Joseph he heard he could interpret dreams, but Joseph told Pharaoh it was God who would provide the interpretation, not him.
    + Pharaoh recounted his 2 dreams to Joseph.
    + In the first dream, 7 healthy cows came up out of the Nile River, followed by 7 skinny and ugly cows.
    + The 7 skinny cows at the 7 healthy cows but remained just as skinny as before.
    + In Pharaoh's 2nd dream, 7 healthy ears of grain grew from one stock, but they were joined by 7 ugly ears that were "blighted by the east wind."
    + The 7 ugly ears of grain swallowed up the 7 healthy ears.
    + Joseph told Pharaoh God had revealed the interpretation to him.
    + Pharaoh's similar dreams shared the same interpretation.
    + The 7 healthy cows and ears of grain symbolized 7 years of abundance.
    + The 7 skinny cows and the 7 withered ears represented 7 years of famine.
    + Egypt would experience 7 years of plenty followed by 7 years of severe famine.
    + Joseph told Pharaoh to appoint a wise man to store up food during the 7 years of plenty so the nation would not starve during the famine.
- JOSEPH IS PROMOTED TO POWER (41:37-46):
    + Pharaoh decided Joseph was the man he needed for the job.
    + He made Joseph the second most powerful man in the land of Egypt.
    + Joseph was given a wife and a new name, Zaphenath-paneah.
    + Joseph was 30 years old when he was honored by Pharaoh.
- 7 YEARS OF ABUNDANCE (41:47-52):
    + During the 7 years of abundance Joseph gathered grain in storehouses.
    + The year before the famine Joseph had 2 sons, Manasseh and Ephraim.
- THE BEGINNING OF FAMINE (41:53-57):
    + At the end of the 7 years of abundance, the famine began.
    + The Egyptians and those from surrounding nations came to Joseph to buy food.

Application:

- Joseph proceeded confidently into a task that required God's help to succeed.
- When Pharaoh asked Joseph if he could interpret dreams, Joseph confidently replied that God would give him the interpretation.
- He stated it positively and without qualifiers.
- He did not doubt that God would help him because he was returning the glory to God.
- Is our faith ambitions enough to undertake a task that necessitates God's help? Or do we only undertake work we are confident our personal skillset can complete?